

ASSESSMENT BRIEF

Module title	Postgraduate Study and Research Methods
Module code	COM742
Module leader	Julie Mayers
Assessment title	Assignment 1 Part 2 Critical Research
Submission deadline	29 December 2025
Expected date for return of marks and feedback	Grades and feedback will be available on Moodle under the 'Assessment and Feedback' section. This will be made available within 15 working days and consist of annotations on the submission.
Module outcomes assessed	1. Display a mastery of communicating computing and IT related information 2. Critically evaluate complex information from a variety of sources
Assessment weighting	30%
Word count	1000 words (+/- 10%)

Assessment task details

This individual assignment is designed specifically to allow you to demonstrate your research skills, methodological rigour, and ability to critically analyse and interpret data.

Privacy Rights

Privacy Rights is a highly debated topic within Computer Science with the rise of Social Media, The Dark Web, Instant digital communication as well as monitoring and surveillance through digital means.

There are many strong opinions on both side of this augment and your overall task is to research this topic with an open mind then write, in the style of a professional magazine article, a 1,000-word overview of the subject, considering and separating facts from assumptions, from opinion, from flagrant distortion. This, in turn must be based on credible, publicly-available material (which you cite) and not any of your own opinions or preconceptions.

Ensure that you finish your article by drawing conclusions from your research and analysis.

References – Your assignment must be supported by an appropriate reference base in IEEE format. References do not count towards the word count.

Guidance and submission instructions

On submission, a Turnitin check will be performed automatically and unusually high levels of similarity will be flagged to the marker. By submitting this work, you confirm that you have read, understand and accept the university's regulations regarding plagiarism and agree to be dealt with accordingly if any such situation should arise.

Work should be submitted as a single Word or PDF document only, containing your assignment and a reference list. No appendices are required. This report should be written using the correct grammar and referencing skills; it must be formatted appropriately and submitted online via the appropriate Turnitin submission link found on the module space.

You will work on this assignment **individually** and submit your work in a single file to Moodle. In working individually, you must not share your ideas, data or other work product with other students.

Hints and tips

When researching this topic it would be helpful to consider the following perspectives:

- Employees/Individuals/Wider Social Acceptance
- Organisations/Employers
- Military/Defence
- Law Enforcement

All submitted work is expected to observe academic standards in terms of referencing, academic writing, use of language etc. Failure to adhere to these instructions may result in your work being awarded a lower grade than it would otherwise deserve.

Marking and moderation

All grades/marks are indicative and may change when moderated – see the last page for the marking criteria.

Penalties for late submission

Work submitted up to a week late without a valid reason can only gain a maximum of 40%. If an extension is required, then an [Request for Extension to Assignment Deadline](#) Form **must be completed and agreed prior to the submission date**.

Any work submitted more than a week late without a valid reason may be read but will not be marked.

Support arrangements

Support will be provided via Moodle, lectures, and MS Teams. If students have any special requirements, they are advised to inform the lecturer.

For additional support see the [Learning Skills department](#). Here you can access the Academic Skills Tutors, Digital Learning Facilitators, and Academic Support Librarians.

Employability Skills Applied

On successful completion of this module, a student will have had opportunities to demonstrate achievement of the following Employability Skills:

Tick all that apply.

CORE ATTRIBUTES

Engaged	✓
Creative	✓
Enterprising	
Ethical	✓

KEY ATTITUDES

Commitment	✓
Curiosity	✓
Resilient	✓
Confidence	✓
Adaptability	✓

PRACTICAL SKILLSETS

Digital fluency	✓
Organisation	✓
Leadership and team working	
Critical thinking	✓
Emotional intelligence	✓
Communication	✓

Marking Criteria						
ELEMENT	ASSESSMENT TASK	<40:	40%+:	50%+:	60%+:	70%+:
Introduction Weighting 10%	A suitable introduction setting the scene for the research	Insufficient or inappropriate introduction	Mainly reasonable introduction	A good introduction setting the scene for the research	A very good introduction setting the scene for the research	An excellent introduction setting the scene for the research
General discussion and critical analysis Weighting: 30% LO 1, 2	General discussion of drivers and obstacles to the TS. Discuss credibility of claims and counterclaims	Insufficient general discussion or insufficient depth. Insufficient or inappropriate critical analysis and evaluation	A reasonable general discussion, relevant for the most part, with some awareness and application of critical analysis and evaluation	A good, relevant general discussion, with sound awareness and application of critical analysis and evaluation	A very good, relevant general discussion, with complete awareness and strong application of critical analysis and evaluation	A professional, academic treatment of the general topic.
Specific discussion and critical analysis Weighting 30% LO: 2	Considering different arguments and points of view. Seeking balance based on evidence.	insufficient specific discussion or insufficient depth or inappropriate focus	A reasonable specific discussion, relevant for the most part, with some awareness and application of critical analysis and evaluation	A good, relevant specific discussion, with sound awareness and application of critical analysis and evaluation	A very good, relevant specific discussion, with complete awareness and strong application of critical analysis and evaluation.	A professional, academic treatment of the specific topic.
Conclusions Weighting 20% LO: 2	Logical conclusions to be drawn from the body of the discussion.	Insufficient conclusions or mainly non-sequiturs drawn	Some appropriate conclusions are drawn	Sound conclusions are drawn	Sound conclusions are drawn and demonstrated by clear argument	Conclusions are logically complete.
Presentation Weighing 5%	Present your work in a clear and professional manner	Insufficient or inappropriate presentation	Reasonable level of presentation	A good presentation of your work	A very good presentation of your work	An excellent presentation of your work.
Reference base Weighting 5%	Provide a suitable set of verifiable sources to support your discussion	Inadequate or inappropriate reference base	Adequate reference base in terms of size and focus.	Sound reference base in terms of size and focus.	Good reference base in terms of size and focus.	Excellent reference base in terms of size and focus.